

a good knowledge of automation technologies like Puppet and Chef, as well as with experience on PaaS services like CloudFoundry, etc. The big IT vendors like Cisco, HP, Dell, IBM, NetApp, Red Hat, VMware and many others have devoted significant resources to emerging cloud technologies like OpenStack, and have also formulated their go-to market strategies around the cloud. The availability of support options for enterprises from IT vendors around open source cloud technologies is going to drive enterprise adoption of these open technologies and generate a lot of jobs. OpenStack has become the *de facto* standard for open cloud design and deployments. Also, the new emerging FOSS technologies like NoSQL, OpenStack and Hadoop are changing the way traditional enterprises have thought of open source. OpenStack provides enterprise users with a lot of flexibility, scalability, great support from vendors, freedom from vendor lock-in and a very dynamic ecosystem to be a part of," explains Kavitha.

Skills in Web development will also be sought after

This year will also see Web development skills featuring high on the wishlist of hiring managers. According to industry leaders, skills like Drupal, PHP, HTML5, CSS, jQuery and jQuery Mobile will be in demand this year. Najeem M Illyas, senior technology architect at Cognizant Technology Solutions, explains, "One must know why these skills will be in demand. Companies are attracted to open source in order to reduce their overheads in development and maintenance. Open source software, such as server applications and tools, are freely available and maintained by open source communities. More and more professionals are contributing to FOSS. The availability of skilled resources in FOSS is a major attraction in the job market. FOSS capabilities in cross-platform application development are attractive to all levels of companies." According to Illyas, Drupal skills are majorly in demand, and candidates with a background in PHP and MySQL development along with project experience in Drupal can thrive in the industry. But demand for mobile solutions is also increasing, with open source platforms extending Drupal capabilities to jQuery Mobile and other JavaScript-based UI techniques.

So what qualities do big firms like Cognizant Technology Solutions look for in prospective applicants? "We are hiring open source professionals to develop Web applications for our corporate clients. When it comes to project-specific hiring for FOSS, we look for core competency in the fields of Drupal and PHP, especially in the LAMP stack. Most of our hiring is based on the demand, but we are maintaining an open source development pool as well. Skills in HTML5 are also at a premium, as that's what is required in the smartphone and tablet industry. Mostly, we look for people who have the flexibility to work with multiple technology stacks or with varied development and UI capabilities. Candidates should know enough about application performance bottlenecks and other security concerns," says Illyas.

According to industry experts, Drupal is scalable and performs well when optimised as suggested by the open source community. But it performs poorly when employed with wrong configurations and incomplete optimisations. Developers also need to be aware of various non-functional requirements such as support for multiple browsers or various operating systems like iOS, Android, Mac, etc. With regard to cross-platform UI technologies, HTML5 is a much-desired skill for developers.

Boost employability with mobile app development skills

All those who want to ensure job security for the next few years should sharpen their IT skills in the mobile app development terrain. According to a study by Robert Half Technology, a leading technology placement company, an increased demand in this domain has made it challenging for firms to find candidates with the right mobile app development skills. K Murugesh Babu, business development manager, Products and Online Marketing at Agriya, a leading Web development company, shares that when it comes to mobile app development, Android is the hottest of them all. "Most users want to manage their productivity, daily activities, store data in the cloud, manage their websites, and do a lot of their work within a short span of time. Besides, the number of Android users is increasing at a rapid pace and so are their requirements. All of which has resulted in an increasing demand for mobile applications," says Murugesh Babu. Agriya, a company that hires open source professionals, looks for candidates who have some basic knowledge about the technology they are going to apply. And experience and certified industry-specific skills are always a plus. "Listening and interpersonal skills are the major priority for any organisation. Most open source companies want applicants to have a thirst for learning new concepts, have the capability to understand them effectively and apply their knowledge appropriately to bring in the profits for their enterprise. They want applicants who work smartly," adds Murugesh Babu.

All things Java

Experts believe that the job market is looking up in yet another booming segment—Java and the demand for proficient Java professionals will continue to grow in the years to come. Vineet Tyagi, associate vice president at Impetus, shares, "If you look at the IT recruitment trends, whether past or current, the demand for tech professionals with Java knowhow has never slackened but has only continued to increase manifold. Moreover, a perfect blend of Hadoop and Java skills is the order of the day as Hadoop is a Java-based framework. Impetus hires open source professionals and while recruiting, apart from strong domain knowledge, we look for skills like versatility, the ability to find solutions, an aptitude for self-learning and the ability to work on a multi-faceted platform."